

A Founder's Playbook · 2026

Building an AI- Native Startup

The startup lifecycle, rebooted for the
agentic era.

Chapter 02

What it means to be a founder is changing

Chapter 03

Idea Stage

Defining and pressure-testing the problem hypothesis

Your own domain expertise and up-front research have already generated a hypothesis. The first job is to sharpen it until it's actually testable. **Claude is particularly useful here for forcing specificity:** who exactly has this problem, how often, how severely, and what do they currently do about it?

Sharpen the statement

A problem statement that can't answer those questions precisely isn't ready to validate. The goal is to arrive at customer discovery with assumptions already stress-tested.

EXERCISE Work with Claude to sharpen your problem statement until it's a testable hypothesis. "Contract review takes too long" is not testable. "In-house legal teams at mid-market companies spend 3+ days per cycle because redlines live across email threads" is.

Find disconfirming evidence

- Ask Claude to argue against your idea, not for it.
- Surface negative market signals and failed competitors in the same space.
- Map structural obstacles a supportive synthesis would have buried.

NOTE Using Claude as a structured devil's advocate is a core use case at every stage of the AI startup life cycle, not just here.

Choosing the right Claude surface

AI makes it easier to ship faster, automate workflows, and operate at scale — but the surface you use matters. Here's when to reach for which.

If the task is...	Reach for	Why
A question, a rewrite, a quick brainstorm	Chat	Fast, conversational, no setup
Research, analysis, or a finished document built from your files	Cowork	Folder access, connectors, scheduled runs
Writing, testing, or shipping software	Code	Codebase access, diffs, git, dev environments

The three share the same Claude underneath; what changes is the workspace around it.